

GUIANAN SQUIRREL MONKEY

Saimiri sciureus

Inquisitive and intelligent, the Guianan squirrel monkey has the largest brain mass to body mass of any primate. It is also very social, living in large mixed-sex groups of around 15–50 individuals.

Guianan squirrel monkeys are synchronous breeders, with all young being born over a single week during the wet season (January–February) after a gestation period of about six months. The young initially cling to their mother's abdomen but then start riding on her back at about two weeks old. Their development is rapid, and the youngsters are weaned at six months and are fully independent four months later. Squirrel monkeys can live for up to 20 years.



SIZE 25–37 cm (10–14½ in)

HABITAT Lowland rainforest, mangroves

DISTRIBUTION French Guiana, Guyana, Suriname, and Brazil north of the Amazon

DIET Mainly insects, spiders, fruits, and flowers

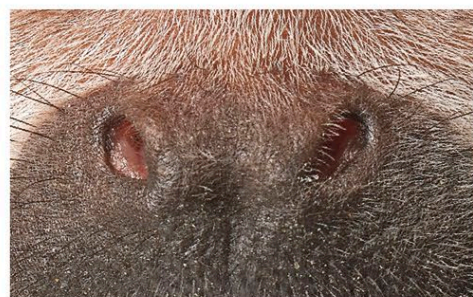
EYE >

Sharp vision and good depth perception are a result of having large, close-set, forward-facing eyes. These features are of vital importance to a monkey that spends most of its time in the trees.



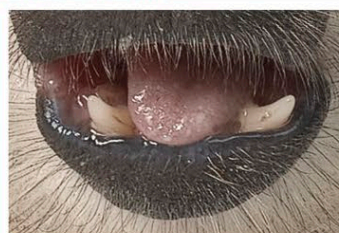
< NOSTRILS

Broad, laterally facing nostrils and a short nasal region belie an excellent sense of smell. Scent is important for social communication between members of the group and for finding mates and lost infants.



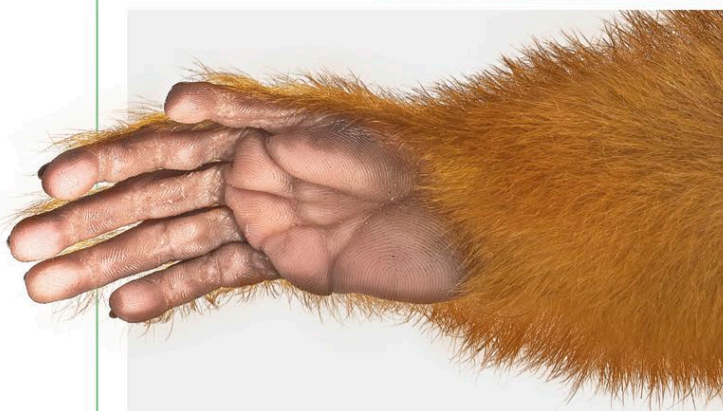
^ TEETH

The Guianan squirrel monkey has 36 small, sharp teeth. The canines are longer and more prominent than the other teeth, and males have larger upper canines than females.



^ HAND

Although the hand is used to grip branches, hold food, self-groom, and perform other tasks, the fingers do not move independently, so the thumb and first finger cannot be opposed and used to pick things up.



^ FOOT

Unlike the hand, the foot has a large, opposable digit – the big toe. When used in conjunction with the other four toes, it allows the foot to grasp branches.



BALANCING ACT >

The tail is at least as long as the head and body lengths combined. It is used to help with balance on tree branches as squirrel monkeys move on all fours.



body covered
by a short,
thick coat